to the Bay of Bengal to deter China and show support for India. It was also a far cry from the 1965 war, when the US warned China against attacking India and dusted off its contingency plans to support India in case it did so.

The deployment of the *Enterprise* was the most visible evidence of how, between 1969 and 1972, American and Indian convergence on China unraveled. Initially during this period there were simultaneous but separate US and Indian efforts to seek a rapprochement with China. Nixon and Kissinger's initiative would bear fruit. The Indian government's efforts to improve relations with China, however, would not yield significant results. Once again, American and Indian perceptions of and policy toward China would diverge, with a detrimental impact on the US-India relationship. Kissinger later noted that in Nixon's world, there were arenas for cooperation and arenas of clashing interests.[4] And, in this period, India moved from the former to the latter.

The White House's altered attitude and approach to China adversely affected the US-India relationship in three ways. First, Pakistan was a key facilitator—the crucial means to a critical end—in the route to rapprochement. Second, Nixon and Kissinger saw India, particularly with its actions related to the 1971 Bangladesh crisis, as a spoiler as they sought to engage China. Third, rapprochement with China considerably diminished India's importance in the US strategic framework.

On the other hand, the Indian government, led by Indira Gandhi, continued to see China as a challenge, alone and in collusion with Pakistan. This threat loomed larger in 1971 when there was a real prospect of an India-Pakistan war, with China lining up on Pakistan's side. During the crisis, Indian policymakers found that American protection against China, which they had implicitly counted on, was no longer available. To make matters worse, the White House did not stay neutral. Instead, Indian officials believed that after Sino-American rapprochement, the US lined up with China and Pakistan against India. This led to Delhi signing a treaty with the Soviet Union as an insurance policy. During and after the crisis in India, the idea of a Beijing-Washington plan to use Islamabad to contain India took hold. This sentiment bled into every aspect of the relationship as the two countries disentangled from each other.

This chapter considers this eventful four-year period, outlining the Nixon administration's views of China and India when it came to office, as well as